



arcade ■ games

Six feet unde

We dig up a few games that died even before they were released and conduct an autopsy to discover why some developers bury their beloved creations alive

In the fictitious *Chicken Soup for the Game Developer's Soul*, just before the philosophical discourse on the 'When it's Done' policy, lies the 'Hype Manifesto'. It reads thus: 'Hype your creation to the sky. Glorify each diminutive, negative aspect of your game. Let your Web site be an endless source of screenshots and pre-production artwork—learn from the success of *Diablo II*.'

In all seriousness though, within the game development business, ensuring visibility for your creation is an absolute must. Publicity and hype are the evils that every development studio with the intent of making a profit, must attend to. As much as we hate the hype machine that is put into overdrive before the release of a game, what reduces us to a frenzied mass of nerves is the termination of the project that was moments ago touted as the next best thing to sliced bread! The surest way that a development studio can rub off a fan the wrong way is simple: generate enough hype to reduce a gamer to a mindless zombie, wherein the said soul praises your game morning, noon and night—across message boards and pubs alike—then just as the doomed one's eyes start glazing over with that crazed, worshipping look, terminate the game! Much pain and anguish will follow. Why would a gaming company do this to their fans?

There are a number of reasons why a game is terminated—unrealistic cost calculations, shifting market trends, prolonged development processes and technical woes. A game might even be shelved simply because it didn't match up to the developer's expectations. Let us take a look at the reasons involved, in the hope of gaining a new perspective into the game development process.

It's the money, honey

Most of the problems in life can be traced to the absence of little green pieces of paper. Like everything else, creating a game requires a healthy dosage of this green energy, that is, lots of money.

Bills have to be paid, Web sites need to be maintained, computers need to be bought and upgraded with painful regularity, then there is that little detail of sending out the salary slips to this and a billion other places that money finds its way into, haunt game developers both big and small. The source of this money is usually the publisher, who becomes a demigod of sorts—someone that dictate the course of a game routinely delivered from boardroom to the brains behind the game. Developers, while, have little choice but to listen and to obey. Even if you are an independent game developer (a rare breed), you need a good bank account, a generous spouse.

It should thus come as no surprise when a game project is cancelled because of lack of funds. Take the case of *The Y Project*, a German development house that had licensed the Unreal Engine to create, what they hoped, would be a good blend of action and strategy playing elements—*The Y Project*. The company found itself in troubled financial waters and despite very positive feedback on the games from the international market, a sustainable source of funding was not be ensured. With no other options left, Westka filed for insolvency and more than 44 employees were laid off. The company had to eventually close its business operations on October 2002. Although not officially dead, *The Y Project* now shows zero chance of life.

Glance through a veteran gamer's favourites and chances are that you will find upon a little gem titled *X-Com: UFO Defense*. The game has an army of dedicated fans. Even venerable game developers swear by the title. It was thus surprising to learn that Mythos Games had to abandon work on the sequel, *Dreamland Chronicles: Freedom Riders*, for monetary reasons. "It is with great regret that I have to announce that *Dreamland Chronicles* has been cancelled. We have been looking for a



IMAGING: Solomon Lewis